

# Noble Lion's Roar of Queen Śrīmālā

Āryaśrīmālādevīsiṃhanāda nāma mahāyānasūtra · Toh 92 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ལ་མྱོད་པལ་ཡེ་ག་སེང་གའི་སྒྲུབ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན་

The Lion's Roar of Queen Śrīmālā, known in Sanskrit as the  
Āryaśrīmālādevīsiṃhanāda and in Tibetan as

འཕགས་པ་ལ་མྱོད་པལ་ཡེ་ག་སེང་གའི་སྒྲུབ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན་, is a Mahāyāna sūtra centered on the teachings of the noble queen Śrīmālā, who delivers a celebrated discourse on the nature of the tathāgatagarbha, the one vehicle, and the path to liberation. The text takes the form of a dialogue set at Śrāvastī, in which Queen Śrīmālā, daughter of King Prasenajit and Queen Mallikā, expounds profound doctrines before the Buddha, who affirms and praises her understanding. It is one of the most influential Indian Buddhist scriptures on buddha-nature theory, widely studied across Mahāyāna traditions. This text is Toh 92 in the Kangyur, where it appears as the forty-eighth chapter of the vast sūtra collection known as the Great Jewel Heap, and belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras.

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From the noble Great Jewel Heap, a collection of Dharma teachings in one hundred thousand chapters, this is the forty-eighth chapter: the teaching on the lion's roar of the noble goddess Śrīmālā. The first portion.

In the language of India: Āryaśrīmālādevīsiṃhanāda nāma mahāyānasūtra.

In the Tibetan language: the sūtra of the Great Vehicle known as the Noble Lion's Roar of Queen Śrīmālā.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One (the Buddha) was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada.

Then, at that time, King Prasenajit of the land of Kośala and his noble queen, Queen Mallikā, began conversing not long after the goddess Śrīmālā had come to understanding of the Dharma. The queen said: "O great king, your daughter, the goddess Śrīmālā, is intelligent, clear-minded, profound, and learned. If she were to behold the Blessed One, she would understand the Dharma with little difficulty, and she would have no doubt whatsoever regarding the teaching of Dharma by the Blessed One."

Thereupon, King Prasenajit of Kośala spoke thus to Queen Mallikā: "Mallikā, then it would be well for us to send a capable messenger to the goddess Śrīmālā."

When he had spoken, Queen Mallikā heard the words of King Prasenajit, and together King Prasenajit of Kośala and Queen Mallikā composed a letter in many passages praising the qualities of the Blessed One. They then sent it in the hand of a trustworthy court attendant named Candraketu, and he departed. He traveled to the city of Ayodhyā and came into the presence of the queen's retinue. He paid homage to the goddess Śrīmālā, exchanged words of mutual rejoicing, and placed the letter in the hands of the goddess Śrīmālā.

Then Śrīmālā, with reverence toward her parents, received the letter with both hands, touched it to her head, and read the letter herself. Having received the meaning of the letter as good, having taken it to heart as meaningful, she bowed her head, held it as something wondrous, and the goddess Śrīmālā spoke these verses to the attendant Candraketu:

The very word "buddha" — awakened one —  
is exceedingly rare within this world.  
If this word is true,  
then I shall dedicate myself in return.

If that Blessed One, that buddha,  
has arisen for the benefit of the world,  
may he appear here before me  
out of compassion, to teach.

Then in that very instant  
the Protector came and stood in the sky above.  
She beheld the inconceivable body of the buddha  
abiding there, radiating rays of light.

At that moment the goddess  
rose with her full retinue in reverence,  
joined her palms at her crown,  
and offered this praise to the supreme speaker:

"O Protector, your body and its beauty  
are without equal anywhere.  
To the guardian of the world, incomparable  
and beyond all analogy and measure, I bow.  
O Protector, even your body and your gnosis  
are without superior.

Your buddha-Dharma is beyond all measure.  
Therefore, O Sage, you are my refuge as well.

You of immeasurable power,  
who have cleared all faults of body, speech, and mind,  
who have attained the ground of no-decline —  
to you, the Dharma king, I bow.

You know all that is to be known,  
sovereign of the body of gnosis.  
To you, who have perfected  
all the qualities and phenomena of buddhahood, I bow.

To you, the immeasurable, I bow.  
To you, beyond all analogy, I bow.  
To you, the Dharma beyond conception, I bow.  
To you, the form without limit, I bow.

I am now protected by the Protector;  
the seed of awakening has been fully awakened within me."

"In other existences to come, may the Sage bestow benefit upon me."

The Blessed One declared: "Goddess, in former lives I formed the connection of awakening with you, and in future lives as well, across other existences, I shall continue to hold you in my care."

The goddess Śrīmālā then beseeched him: "Whatever merit I have made in this life and in others — by that merit, may I always behold you, O Protector."

Then the goddess Śrīmālā, together with all the queens and the entire retinue fully assembled, touched their heads to the feet of the Blessed One.

Thereupon, in the midst of the gathered assembly, the Blessed One bestowed upon the goddess Śrīmālā a prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He declared: "Goddess, through this root of virtue — the merit you have accumulated by praising the Tathāgata with true and genuine qualities — you shall for immeasurable and incalculable eons enjoy the splendor of divine and human sovereignty. In every lifetime you shall never be separated from beholding me, and you shall be praised face to face with praises such as these. You shall also make offerings to immeasurable and incalculable blessed buddhas. Then, after twenty incalculable hundreds of thousands of eons from now, you shall become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a fully and perfectly awakened

buddha by the name Samantabhadra. At that time, in your buddha-field, no lower realms shall arise. At that time, sentient beings shall abide on the path of the ten virtuous actions. Those sentient beings shall have no illness and no old age, and no harm that is unwelcome; even the names of the paths of non-virtuous karma shall not be heard. The sentient beings who take birth in that buddha-field shall surpass even the gods of the realm who wield power over others' magical creations in happiness, form, complexion, splendor, majesty, shape, sound, scent, taste, touch, and all enjoyments whatsoever — those beings shall be endowed with supreme happiness. Goddess, all sentient beings who take birth in that buddha-field shall be perfectly entered into the Great Vehicle. Goddess, in that way, sentient beings who have created roots of virtue shall at that time gather in that buddha-field."

Upon hearing this excellent prophecy of the goddess Śrīmālā, immeasurable gods and humans made aspiration prayers to be born in that buddha-field. The Blessed One then gave his prophecy that all of them would indeed be born in that world-realm.

Then the goddess Śrīmālā, having heard from the Blessed One his prophecy directly to herself, joined her palms together and perfectly undertook ten great solemn pledges. What are the ten? They are as follows:

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not give rise to a mind that would transgress the time of moral discipline. Blessed One, I perfectly undertake this first pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not give rise to a mind of disrespect toward teachers. Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this second pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not give rise anywhere to a mind of anger or a mind of ill will toward any sentient being.

Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this third pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not give rise to a mind of envy toward the glory of others or toward the good fortune of others. Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this fourth pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not give rise to a mind of miserliness even with regard to so little as a morsel of food. Blessed One, I also perfectly

undertake this fifth pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not hold wealth for the sake of enjoying it for myself alone. Rather, Blessed One, I wish to hold wealth in order to bring to full maturation sentient beings who are poor, suffering, and without protector. Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this sixth pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not gather sentient beings to myself through the four means of attraction merely in hopes that they will be of benefit to me. Rather, Blessed One, I wish to gather sentient beings sincerely, with a mind free of material interest, without regarding any amount as enough, and without turning back. Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this seventh pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward, whenever I see sentient beings who are without protector, who have been delivered into servitude, who are bound in chains, who are afflicted by illness, who are in suffering, who have become poor and destitute, or who are eking out a living in great hardship, I shall not abandon them by so much as a single step without offering them care. Blessed One, whenever I see those sentient beings tormented by suffering, I shall first fully liberate them from each and every one of those sufferings, and then, having accomplished that through the gathering of wealth, I shall afterwards draw near to them myself. Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this eighth pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward, whenever I see those who make their living by the sinful livelihood of trading in pigs, birds, and the like, or those whose conduct has fallen away from the Dharma of the Vinaya as taught by the Tathāgata, I shall not let them go to waste and abandon them. Blessed One, in whatever villages, cities, market towns, districts, or royal palaces I am received and heard, toward those who deserve to be disciplined I shall act to discipline them, and toward those who deserve to be tended with medicine I shall act to tend them with medicine. And why is this? Blessed One, it is because through discipline and through offering medicine the holy Dharma will long endure in the world. And when the holy Dharma long endures, the bodies of gods and humans will greatly flourish and the lower realms will be entirely extinguished. Blessed One, this is to follow in the wake of the turning of the wheel of Dharma by the Blessed One. Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake

this ninth pledge until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, from this day forward I shall not give rise even to a single thought that would abandon the upholding of the holy Dharma. And why is this? Blessed One, if one abandons the upholding of the holy Dharma, one abandons the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, if one abandons the Great Vehicle, one abandons the perfections.

Blessed One, if one abandons the perfections, one will turn away from the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, whatever bodhisattva, great being, is undecided about the Great Vehicle will turn away from upholding the holy Dharma and will abide in self-diminishment. Blessed One, such a one will be destined to fall to the level of childish, ordinary persons. Blessed One, I see this as a great fault and a great harm. Blessed One, I see that from the upholding of the holy Dharma there will be accomplished immeasurable and incalculable benefit for myself and for the bodhisattvas of the future. Therefore, Blessed One, I also perfectly undertake this tenth pledge of upholding the holy Dharma until the very end, until the heart of awakening itself.

Blessed One, these ten great pledges of mine have been undertaken in the presence of the Blessed One, and in this the Blessed One himself is sovereign over this Dharma. Blessed One, although the Teacher is present before me in person, there may be some sentient beings of meagre roots of virtue who think, alas, that these ten great pledges are difficult to fulfil, and who harbour doubt or uncertainty about me. Those very beings will, for a long time to come, be harmed, made to suffer, and ruined by that same doubt. Therefore, in order to be of medicine to those very beings, I wish to perform before the Blessed One this act of truth-blessing. Blessed One, regarding these ten great pledges that I have undertaken — if, Blessed One, I shall indeed act precisely as I have spoken, then by this true word of mine, may a rain of divine flowers fall in this assembled maṇḍala of the retinue, may a divine sound ring out, and may that too receive this blessing of my truth.

The moment the goddess Śrīmālā (Śrīmālādevī) had spoken those words, a great rain of divine flowers fell and a divine sound rang out from the sky. That sound, having received the blessing of truth, affirmed: "Just as you have performed the act of truth-blessing, so shall it be — it shall not be otherwise."

Then, having witnessed that wondrous miracle and having heard that divine sound, the entire assembled retinue was freed from all doubt and filled with supreme joy. They made aspirational prayers never to be separated from the

goddess Śrīmālā, to be her companions always. The Blessed One then gave a prophecy that all those in the retinue would likewise never be parted from her.

Thereupon the goddess Śrīmālā made three great aspirational prayers in the presence of the Blessed One. What are the three? Blessed One, by the root of virtue accumulated through the merit of having, by this act of truth-blessing, been of medicine to immeasurable sentient beings, may I, the Blessed One, in all my future lives attain the realisation of the holy Dharma. Blessed One, this is my first great aspiration.

Blessed One, having attained that realisation of the holy Dharma, may I teach the Dharma to sentient beings without weariness or despondency. Blessed One, this is my second great aspiration.

Blessed One, having thus taught the holy Dharma, may I guard the holy Dharma and uphold the holy Dharma without regard for body or life. Blessed One, this is my third great aspiration. Blessed One, I make these three great aspirations.

Then the Blessed One gave a prophecy concerning these three great aspirations of vast scope made by the goddess Śrīmālā. He said: "Goddess, just as all that belongs to the realm of form is gathered within, belongs within, and is contained within the element of space, so too, Goddess, whatever aspirations a bodhisattva may make — as many as the grains of sand in the river Ganges — are all gathered within, belong within, and are contained within these three great aspirations. These three great aspirations are thus of vast scope."

Then the goddess Śrīmālā addressed the Blessed One and said: "Blessed One, that the scope of the great aspiration has been taught in this way — I have also been emboldened to speak further by the power of the Tathāgata." The Blessed One declared: "Goddess, the Tathāgata grants you permission. Speak boldly."

Then the goddess Śrīmālā again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, all those bodhisattva aspirations as many as the grains of sand in the river Ganges are entirely gathered within and contained within this one great aspiration: the aspiration to uphold the holy Dharma. Blessed One, upholding the holy Dharma is thus of vast scope."

Then the Blessed One gave his approval and said "Excellent!" to the goddess Śrīmālā: "Goddess, excellent, excellent! Goddess, you are profound in wisdom

— you possess wisdom fully ripened by skillful means. Those sentient beings who have understood the meaning of the Dharma you have taught are rare indeed; they have cultivated roots of virtue over a long time in the presence of many buddhas. Goddess, just as you have taught the meaning of upholding the holy Dharma, so too have all the Tathāgatas of the past, the future, and the present taught — and teach — and will teach — that very same teaching on upholding the holy Dharma. Goddess, I too, having now attained the supreme and perfect awakening, teach the meaning of upholding the holy Dharma in many ways. And yet, Goddess, even though I have taught the meaning of upholding the holy Dharma in many ways, the virtues of upholding the holy Dharma have no end or limit. The fearless eloquence of the Tathāgata likewise has no end or limit. Goddess, upholding the holy Dharma is thus of great significance. Goddess, upholding the holy Dharma is thus of great benefit."

Then the goddess Śrīmālā addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, by the power of the Tathāgata, I will be bold and speak further on this great matter." The Blessed One declared: "Goddess, if you know the right moment has come, then speak boldly."

Having received the Blessed One's permission, the goddess Śrīmālā again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, upholding the holy Dharma brings to perfect completion all the immeasurable qualities of a buddha. Blessed One, upholding the holy Dharma encompasses the eighty-four thousand doors of Dharma. Blessed One, for example, a great cloud at the time of the summer rains possesses an endless stream of water and an endless stream of precious things. In the same way, Blessed One, upholding the holy Dharma too possesses an immeasurable stream of waters — the maturation of merit — and an immeasurable stream of precious gnosis."

Blessed One, for example, at the time of the great rains, from a single vast mass of water, there arise in the great trichiliocosm — that world-realm of a billion worlds — four continents numbering ten billion, of various colors and various shapes; and eighty-four billion surrounding sub-continents arise from that single great mass of water. In the same way, Blessed One, upholding the holy Dharma is the source and birthplace from which the perfect accomplishment of the Great Vehicle arises. From it arise all the magical manifestations of bodhisattvas, all the various gates through which the Dharma shines forth, all worldly excellences, all worldly sovereignties, and all transcendent joys — those joys beyond the world that gods and humans have



never before experienced.

Blessed One, consider this further analogy: the great earth serves as the support for four great burdens. What are those four? It supports the great mass of water — the vast ocean — and all the many mountains; and it supports grasses, shrubs, medicinal plants, flowers, and all the forests; and it supports the entire assembly of sentient beings. Blessed One, just as the great earth supports these four great burdens, so too, Blessed One, does a son of good family or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma carry four burdens even greater than the great earth. What are those four?

First: a son or daughter of good family who engages sentient beings — those without a spiritual friend, without learning, and without the Dharma — in roots of virtue that will bring them the excellent fortune of gods and humans carries a burden even greater than the great earth.

Second: a son or daughter of good family who engages certain sentient beings in the vehicle of the hearers (*śrāvakas*) carries a burden even greater than the great earth.

Third: a son or daughter of good family who engages certain sentient beings in the vehicle of the solitary buddhas carries a burden even greater than the great earth.

Fourth: a son or daughter of good family who engages certain sentient beings in the Great Vehicle carries a burden even greater than the great earth.

Blessed One, these four are the great burdens. Blessed One, a son or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma carries these four great burdens — greater even than the great earth — and so becomes a support surpassing the great earth, carrying burdens surpassing the great earth, carrying burdens beyond limit, becoming the ground and foundation for all sentient beings. Such a one acts with loving-kindness and is filled with compassion, desires to heal and is tender-hearted, and is rightly called the mother of the world through the Dharma.

Blessed One, consider this further analogy: the great earth is the source of four kinds of precious things. What are those four kinds? It is the source of priceless precious things, the source of precious things of estimable worth, the source of precious things lesser than those, and the source of precious things lesser still. Blessed One, just as the great earth is the source of these four kinds of precious things, in the same way, Blessed One, through relying upon a

son or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma, sentient beings will come to obtain the benefits of four supreme and precious things — the highest of all precious things. What are those four? A spiritual friend who is a son of good family or —

— a daughter of good family, through reliance upon whom sentient beings will come to obtain the benefit of an accumulation of merit that brings them the splendors of gods and humans; through reliance upon whom sentient beings will come to obtain the benefit of acquiring roots of virtue that draw them toward the vehicle of the śrāvakas; through reliance upon whom sentient beings will come to obtain the benefit of acquiring an accumulation of roots of virtue that draw them toward the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas; and through reliance upon whom sentient beings will come to obtain the benefit of acquiring the most exalted accumulation of merit that draws them toward perfect and complete buddhahood. Thus, Blessed One, through relying upon a son or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma, sentient beings will come to obtain the benefit of these four great and wondrous precious things, supreme among all precious things.

Blessed One, the phrase "great treasury, source of limitless precious things" is simply another name for one who upholds the holy Dharma.

Blessed One, as for the phrase "one who upholds the holy Dharma" — the holy Dharma is not one thing and the one who upholds the holy Dharma another. Blessed One, the very one who upholds the holy Dharma is the holy Dharma. Blessed One, the perfections are not one thing and the one who upholds the holy Dharma another. Blessed One, the very one who upholds the holy Dharma is the perfections.

Why is this so, Blessed One? A son or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma thoroughly ripens those sentient beings who are to be ripened through generosity — ripening them by means of generosity, even going so far as to give away the very limbs and members of their body. Having been thoroughly ripened in this way, those beings are established in the holy Dharma. This is that person's perfection of generosity.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who are to be ripened through moral discipline — that person ripens them through the thorough purification of the actions of body, speech, and mind by restraining the six sense faculties, and even guards and ripens their minds through their own conduct. Having thus thoroughly ripened those beings, they are established in the holy Dharma. This

is that person's perfection of moral discipline.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who are to be ripened through patience — even if those beings inflict upon that person the eight worldly conditions and cause them harm, there is not the slightest ill will, but instead a wish to be of benefit; and that person ripens them endowed with the supreme strength of patience, even guarding and ripening their minds through the very radiance of their countenance. Having thoroughly ripened those beings, they are established in the holy Dharma. This is that person's perfection of patience.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who are to be ripened through diligence — that person ripens them with an undaunted mind, free from laziness, endowed with great aspiration and the most excellent application of effort, even guarding and ripening their minds by the vigor of their own conduct. Having thoroughly ripened those beings in this way, they are established in the holy Dharma. This is that person's perfection of diligence.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who are to be ripened through meditative concentration — that person ripens them with an undistractable mind, a mind that does not wander outward,

endowed with supreme non-erring mindfulness, ripening them. Even over long stretches of time after having acted, or over long stretches of time after having spoken, guarding those beings' minds without abandoning them, that person ripens them. Having thus thoroughly ripened those beings, they are established in the holy Dharma. This is that person's perfection of meditative concentration.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who are to be ripened through wisdom — that person ripens them by prophesying tirelessly for those who seek the welfare of sentient beings, and by mastering all treatises and all fields of knowledge and craft. Even in the great workshops, that person guards those beings' minds and ripens them. Having thus thoroughly ripened those beings, they are established in the holy Dharma. This is that person's perfection of wisdom.

Blessed One, this being so, the perfections are nothing other than this, and the upholder of the holy Dharma is nothing other than this. Blessed One, the upholder of the holy Dharma itself is the perfections.

Blessed One, I am emboldened to set forth yet another great matter through the power of the Tathāgata.

The Blessed One declared: Goddess, the Tathāgata grants this — speak with confidence.

Then the goddess Śrīmālā addressed the Blessed One in these words: Blessed One, as for the phrase "upholder of the holy Dharma, upholder of the holy Dharma" — Blessed One, the holy Dharma that is upheld is nothing other than this, and the upholder of the holy Dharma is nothing other than this. Blessed One, the upholder of the holy Dharma herself is the holy Dharma that is upheld.

Why is this so? Blessed One, any son or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma will, for the sake of upholding the holy Dharma, relinquish three limbs. What are the three? They are body, life, and possessions.

Blessed One, a son or daughter of good family who relinquishes the body will attain the buddha's form body — equal to the furthest limit of the end of saṃsāra — free from aging, illness, and death, indestructible, permanent, stable, peaceful, everlasting, beyond transmigration, boundless, and endowed with qualities inconceivable.

Blessed One, a son or daughter of good family who relinquishes life will attain all the buddha's qualities, which abide in wondrous display — equal to the furthest limit of the end of saṃsāra — free from transmigration, boundless, permanent, and endowed with qualities inconceivable.

Blessed One, a son or daughter of good family who relinquishes possessions will attain the veneration of all sentient beings — equal to the furthest limit of the end of saṃsāra — unshared with any sentient being, inexhaustible, free from conceptual elaboration, continuously uninterrupted and ever-present, and endowed with qualities inconceivable.

Blessed One, in this way, when a son or daughter of good family who upholds the holy Dharma relinquishes these three limbs, they will attain those three utterly wondrous qualities, and all buddhas will prophesy it.

Blessed One, at the time when the holy Dharma is in decline, monks and nuns —

lay men (upāsakas) and lay women (upāsikās) are scattered in twos, broken into factions, dispersed in every direction, and fallen into dispute — if, without deceit, without cunning, without pretense, delighting in the Dharma and for the sake of fully upholding the holy Dharma, one enters upon the side of what accords with Dharma, then, Blessed One, that son or daughter of good family

will, by the very act of entering upon it, certainly obtain prophecy from all buddhas.

Blessed One, I hold that upholding the holy Dharma in this way is great diligence. And in this matter, the Blessed One himself is the witness, for he is gnosis itself. The Blessed One is the root of all phenomena. The Blessed One is the sovereign lord. The Blessed One is the Teacher.

Then the Blessed One rejoiced in the goddess Śrīmālā's teaching on the upholding of the holy Dharma and said: Just so, goddess. Goddess, upholding the holy Dharma is great diligence. Goddess, consider this: even when a strong person does not strike with full force, a mere touch causes pain and gives rise to illness. Likewise, goddess, even a small amount of upholding the holy Dharma harms the evil Māra, causing him grief and making him lament.

Goddess, I see no other wholesome quality that so harms the evil Māra, causes him such grief, and makes him lament in the way that upholding the holy Dharma does.

Goddess, consider this further: the foremost bull of the finest herd, by his great height and broad girth, outshines and utterly overwhelms every other member of the herd, radiantly magnificent in every respect. Likewise, goddess, even a small amount of upholding the holy Dharma of the Great Vehicle, by its expansiveness and its great breadth, overwhelms all the wholesome qualities of those who follow the vehicle of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Goddess, consider further: Mount Meru, the king of mountains, by its great height and vast breadth, overwhelms all the dark mountains and stands magnificently supreme. Likewise, goddess, the upholding of the holy Dharma of the Great Vehicle by one who disregards body and life and is endowed with a mind intent on benefiting others — being so expansive and so broad — overwhelms all the wholesome qualities of those followers of the Great Vehicle who have only newly entered the vehicle yet still regard body and life as precious. What need is there to speak of others?

Therefore, goddess, sentient beings should be led to properly embrace the upholding of the holy Dharma; it should be properly taught; it should be properly praised; it should be properly celebrated; it should be memorized and recited.

Goddess, the upholding of the holy Dharma is of such great purpose, of such great fruit, of such great benefit. Goddess, even if I were to speak for incalculable and immeasurable aeons on the qualities and benefits of upholding the holy Dharma, the end or limit of those qualities and benefits of upholding the holy Dharma would not be reached. Goddess, the upholding of the holy Dharma is endowed with limitless qualities in this way.

Goddess, this upholding of the holy Dharma, which all buddhas have cherished and which I have taught — be bold in proclaiming what you yourself have spoken.

Then the Goddess Śrīmālā said "Excellent!" to the Blessed One, and having accepted the Blessed One's encouragement, she addressed the Blessed One as follows.

Blessed One, what is called the holy Dharma is the supreme word of the Great Vehicle. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because all the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and all virtuous qualities both worldly and transcendent, are disclosed by the Great Vehicle.

Blessed One, consider this example: the four great rivers arise from the lake Anavatapta. Blessed One, in just the same way, all the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and all virtuous qualities both worldly and transcendent, arise from the Great Vehicle.

Blessed One, consider another example: whatever variety of seeds there may be, together with grasses, creeping plants, and medicines, and all those forests — they all depend upon the great earth, they rest upon the great earth, and it is there that they grow, increase, and flourish. Blessed One, in just the same way, whatever there are of the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and whatever there are of the virtuous qualities both worldly and transcendent — all of them depend upon the Great Vehicle, rest upon the Great Vehicle, and it is there that they grow, increase, and flourish. Therefore, Blessed One, one who abides in the Great Vehicle and fully upholds the Great Vehicle will thereby also depend upon, rest in, and fully uphold all the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and all virtuous qualities both worldly and transcendent.

Blessed One, these six topics — the abiding of the holy Dharma, the decline of the holy Dharma, individual liberation (pratimokṣa), the Vinaya, going forth, and full ordination — together with whatever of these six topics has been taught and designated by the Blessed One, all proceed from the intention of

the Great Vehicle.

Why is that? Blessed One, this designation called "the abiding of the holy Dharma" has the Great Vehicle as its intent. Blessed One, the very abiding of the Great Vehicle is the abiding of the holy Dharma. Blessed One, this designation called "the decline of the holy Dharma" has the Great Vehicle as its intent. Blessed One, the very decline of the Great Vehicle is the decline of the holy Dharma.

Blessed One, these two things called "individual liberation" and "the Vinaya" are one in meaning; only the syllables differ. Blessed One, what is called the Vinaya is the training of those who follow the Great Vehicle. Why is that? Blessed One, going forth and full ordination exist for the sake of the Tathāgata himself. Therefore, Blessed One, this designation of "the Vinaya," "going forth," and "full ordination" is the aggregate of moral discipline in the rites of the Great Vehicle.

Blessed One, there is no going forth and full ordination within the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Going forth and full ordination are not for the sake of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas as such; rather, Blessed One, it is for the sake of the Tathāgata himself that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas go forth and receive full ordination.

Blessed One, even arhats and pratyekabuddhas go for refuge to the Tathāgata himself, and Blessed One, even arhats and pratyekabuddhas still have something to fear. Why is that? Blessed One, arhats and

pratyekabuddhas dwell with the perception that all formations are unbearably fearful. Blessed One, it is like an executioner raising a sword. Because things are that way, Blessed One, they have not attained the supreme ease of definitive emergence. Blessed One, why is that? Because one who has a refuge does not seek another refuge.

Blessed One, just as sentient beings who are without refuge seek refuge from whatever fears them and wish to escape from those very fears, so too, Blessed One, arhats and pratyekabuddhas have that fear, and being terrified by that fear, they acknowledge going for refuge to the Blessed One himself. Blessed One, arhats and pratyekabuddhas still have fear, and because of that, Blessed One, they still have a remainder of what is subject to birth. They have births that are not exhausted, Blessed One. They have a remainder of what is to be practiced; and therefore they are not pure, they have not completed what was to be done, and they have much yet to do. There are also many other

phenomena to be abandoned by them, and because those have not been abandoned, arhats and pratyekabuddhas are far from the basic space of nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, what is called complete nirvāṇa is a skillful means of the Tathāgatas. Why is that? Because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, having attained nirvāṇa, are endowed with all qualities, whereas arhats and pratyekabuddhas are not endowed with all qualities.

Blessed One, what is called complete nirvāṇa is a skillful means of the Tathāgatas. Why is that? Because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, having attained nirvāṇa, are endowed with inconceivable qualities, whereas arhats and pratyekabuddhas are not endowed with inconceivable qualities.

Blessed One, what is called complete nirvāṇa is a skillful means of the Tathāgatas. Why is that? Because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, having attained nirvāṇa, have abandoned all faults to be abandoned and are endowed with supreme and perfect purity, whereas arhats and pratyekabuddhas are accompanied by the remnants of faults and are characterized by incomplete purity.

Blessed One, what is called complete nirvāṇa is a skillful means of the Tathāgatas. Why is that? It is because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, have attained nirvāṇa. And because things are that way, Blessed One, arhats and pratyekabuddhas are far from the basic space of nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, the four recollections that arhats and pratyekabuddhas hold with satisfaction upon reaching the culmination of the analytical wisdom of liberation are still, Blessed One, held with a deeper intent, still accompanied by a remainder, and

still to be taught through definitive scripture by way of distinguishing them from the provisional meaning. Why is that? Blessed One, there are two kinds of death: two kinds, which are these — death by severance of continuity, and inconceivably dedicated death.

Blessed One, among these, death by severance of continuity belongs to sentient beings who undergo rebirth with renewed connection. Blessed One, inconceivably dedicated death belongs to arhats, pratyekabuddhas, the great bodhisattvas who have attained mastery, and those with mind-made bodies —



and this continues all the way up to the seat of awakening.

Blessed One, of these two kinds of death, it is with reference to death by severance of continuity that the knowledge arises in arhats and pratyekabuddhas: "My births are exhausted." Blessed One, it is in dependence upon having made manifest the fruit that is accompanied by a remainder that the knowledge arises in arhats and pratyekabuddhas: "I have lived the holy life." It is in dependence upon having abandoned what was previously abandoned — namely, the abandonment of the afflictions that involve renewed connection, which abandonment all childish ordinary beings together with gods and humans had not accomplished before, and which the seven trainees have abandoned — that the knowledge arises in arhats and pratyekabuddhas: "What was to be done has been done."

Blessed One, the knowledge "I know nothing other than just this" arises in arhats and pratyekabuddhas with reference to the afflictions to be abandoned by an arhat and with reference to renewed connection in further existence, as the knowledge: "I know nothing other than just this."

Blessed One, that very knowledge of "I know nothing other than just this" is not a complete abandonment of all afflictions, nor does it arise from a thorough search of all births. Why is that? Because, Blessed One, even among arhats and pratyekabuddhas there exist afflictions that have not been abandoned and afflictions pertaining to birth that have not been thoroughly searched out.

Blessed One, afflictions are of two kinds: those that are latent grounds of affliction, and those that are actively arising afflictions. Blessed One, latent grounds are also of four kinds. What are those four? The latent ground of abiding in a single view, the latent ground of abiding in attachment to desire, the latent ground of abiding in attachment to form, and the latent ground of abiding in attachment to existence. Blessed One, these four latent grounds give rise to all actively arising afflictions.

Blessed One, these are momentary — they are co-emergent with the moments of the mind. Blessed One, the latent ground of ignorance, which has existed from beginningless time, is not co-emergent with the mind.

Blessed One, among these four latent grounds, the one that is greatest in power — namely the latent ground of ignorance, which is the basis for all proximate afflictions — cannot be counted, measured, enumerated, compared, or taken as a cause alongside the latent ground of great power that is

attachment to existence. Blessed One, thus the latent ground of ignorance is the greatest in power, and it is also called the ground of abiding in attachment to existence.

Blessed One, as an analogy: the evil māra (Skt. māra), though he belongs among the gods who delight in the creations of others, surpasses those gods in form, color, splendor, power, retinue, and sovereignty. Blessed One, in just the same way, the latent ground of ignorance — which is called the ground of abiding in attachment to existence — surpasses these four latent grounds,

in its secondary afflictions (upakleśas) as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges that serve as its support, in its long co-abiding alongside the four afflictions, in being something that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot fathom with their knowledge, and in being something that is to be destroyed only by the wisdom of awakening of a Tathāgata. Thus, Blessed One, the ground of ignorance is the greatest in power.

This is the second section, and the final one.

Blessed One, as an analogy: through the condition of grasping, the three realms of existence arise from the cause of defiled karma. In just the same way, Blessed One, through the condition of the ground of ignorance, three mental bodies arise for arhats, for pratyekabuddhas, and for bodhisattvas who have attained mastery — and these arise from the cause of undefiled karma. Blessed One, the ground of ignorance is the support from which these three mental bodies arise in those three grounds, and it is the support for the performance of undefiled karma. When the condition is present, what is conditioned arises. Therefore, because the ground of ignorance is the condition for these three mental bodies and for undefiled karma, it shares a name with the ground of abiding in attachment to existence. Nevertheless, it does not share function with the ground of abiding in attachment to existence. Blessed One, the ground of ignorance is entirely distinct from these four latent grounds — it is to be abandoned by those who dwell on the ground of complete liberation, it is to be abandoned on the ground of buddhahood, and it is to be destroyed by the wisdom of awakening of a Tathāgata.

Why is this so? Blessed One, even though arhats and pratyekabuddhas have abandoned the four latent grounds, they do not attain the power of mastery over the exhaustion of defilements, nor do they actualize that exhaustion directly. Blessed One, the very phrase "exhaustion of defilements" is, in fact, a designation that surpasses what belongs to the ground of ignorance.

Therefore, Blessed One, even arhats, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas who belong to the final existence are obscured, cut off, and utterly enveloped by the ground of ignorance, and are rendered unaware, so that they do not seek out and do not realize those various dharmas. Blessed One, because they do not seek out and do not see those various dharmas, they do not abandon and do not purify those very dharmas that are to be abandoned. Blessed One, because those dharmas to be abandoned have not been abandoned and not been purified, they are, Blessed One, liberated from faults only partially — they are not liberated from all faults. They possess purity only partially — they do not possess complete purity in every respect. They possess qualities only partially — they do not possess all qualities in every respect.

Blessed One, those who are liberated from faults only partially and not liberated from all faults, who possess purity only partially and not completely, who possess qualities only partially and not in full — Blessed One, such beings have only a partial comprehension of suffering. They have only a partial abandonment of the origin of suffering. They have only a partial direct realization of the cessation of suffering. They have only a partial cultivation of the path leading to the cessation of suffering.

Blessed One, those who have only a partial comprehension of suffering, only a partial abandonment of the origin of suffering,

only a partial direct realization of the cessation of suffering, and only a partial cultivation of the path leading to the cessation of suffering — such beings, Blessed One, attain a nirvāṇa that is partial, a nirvāṇa that is incomplete. Blessed One, such beings are said to have entered the basic space of nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, those who have a complete comprehension of all suffering, who have abandoned all origin of suffering, who have directly realized all cessation of suffering, and who have cultivated the entire path leading to the cessation of suffering — such beings, Blessed One, in a world shattered by impermanence and ever afflicted by disease, attain nirvāṇa, which is a reality that is peaceful and cool. Blessed One, in a world without a protector, without a refuge, they become the world's protector and refuge.

Why is this so? Blessed One, those who still possess qualities that distinguish better from worse have not attained nirvāṇa. Blessed One, nirvāṇa is attained through equality in wisdom; nirvāṇa is attained through equality in liberation; nirvāṇa is attained through equality in the vision of the wisdom of pure knowing. Therefore, Blessed One, the basic space of nirvāṇa is of one taste —

it is, in this way, equal in the taste of knowing and liberation.

Blessed One, as for those who have not abandoned and purified the ground of the residue of ignorance, they do not share in the one taste of the basic space of nirvāṇa — they are not equal in the taste of knowing and liberation. Why is this so? Because through not having abandoned and purified the ground of the residue of ignorance, they have not abandoned and purified a number of things to be abandoned that exceed the grains of sand in the Ganges River. And because those things to be abandoned exceeding the grains of sand in the Ganges have not been abandoned and purified, there is a corresponding number of things exceeding the grains of sand in the Ganges that have not been attained and directly realized.

Therefore, Blessed One, the ground of the residue of ignorance is the arising ground of all afflictions and secondary afflictions to be abandoned through cultivation. From it arise: the secondary afflictions of mind, the secondary afflictions of calm abiding, the secondary afflictions of insight, the secondary afflictions of meditative concentration, the secondary afflictions of meditative absorption, the secondary afflictions of meditative attainment, the secondary afflictions of yoga, the secondary afflictions of knowing, the secondary afflictions of fruition, the secondary afflictions of realization, the secondary afflictions of power, and the secondary afflictions of fearlessness.

Blessed One, all those secondary afflictions, exceeding in number the grains of sand in the Ganges, that are to be vanquished by the wisdom of a Tathāgata's awakening — every single one of them arises from the ground of the residue of ignorance. Blessed One, the ground of the residue of ignorance is the cause, the basis, and the condition for all secondary afflictions and all manifestations of arising.

Blessed One, those manifestations of arising are momentary — they are concomitant with the moments of mind. Blessed One, the ground of the residue of ignorance, which has existed since beginningless time, is not associated with mind.

Blessed One, the ground of the residue of ignorance is in just this way the basis and support for all those phenomena to be abandoned — those exceeding in number the grains of sand in the Ganges — that are to be vanquished by the wisdom of a Tathāgata's awakening.

Blessed One, consider this example: all the various kinds of seeds, grasses, shrubs, medicinal plants, and forests depend upon the great earth, rest upon

the great earth, and from it they are born, grow, and flourish. Blessed One, if the great earth were to crumble and fall to ruin and cease to exist, then all those various kinds of seeds, grasses, shrubs, medicinal plants, and forests would likewise crumble and fall to ruin and cease to exist.

Blessed One, in just the same way, all those phenomena to be abandoned — those exceeding in number the grains of sand in the Ganges — that are to be vanquished by the wisdom of a Tathāgata's awakening, all of them depend upon the ground of the residue of ignorance, rest upon the ground of the residue of ignorance, and from it they are born, grow, and flourish. Blessed One, when the ground of the residue of ignorance has been abandoned, purified, and caused to cease, then all those phenomena to be abandoned — those exceeding in number the grains of sand in the Ganges — that are to be vanquished by the wisdom of a Tathāgata's awakening will likewise all be abandoned, purified, and caused to cease.

Blessed One, having abandoned and purified all those afflictions and secondary afflictions, and having attained the inconceivable qualities of a buddha exceeding in number the grains of sand in the Ganges, the Tathāgatas attain direct knowledge unobstructed with respect to all phenomena. Endowed with omniscience and all-seeing vision, free from every fault, possessed of every good quality, as sovereigns of the Dharma, lords of the Dharma, and rulers over all phenomena, they arrive at that station and roar the lion's roar: "Birth is exhausted, the holy life has been lived, what had to be done has been done; beyond this very state, nothing further remains to be known."

Blessed One, this being so, this lion's roar of the Tathāgatas is of definitive meaning, and this point is worthy of being prophesied with one voice.

Blessed One, the wisdom expressed as "beyond this very state, nothing further remains to be known" has two aspects.

Blessed One, having achieved the unsurpassed victory of a buddha, the Tathāgata defeats and vanquishes the four māras, and attains the dharmakāya — exalted above all the world, to be beheld by all sentient beings — inconceivable and beyond measure. Seeing truly that, as the sovereign lord of Dharma, unimpeded in every domain of knowable reality, there is nothing more to be done and no ground of realization yet to be realized, and being fully possessed of the power of the ten powers (Skt. daśabala), proceeding to the supreme, unsurpassed ground of fearlessness, and surveying all with the wisdom that knows no obstruction regarding any object of knowledge — it is

with this wisdom that the Tathāgata roars the lion's roar: "Beyond this very state, nothing further remains to be known."

Blessed One, arhats and pratyekabuddhas who have crossed beyond the terrors of saṃsāra and have just attained liberation, experiencing the bliss of that release — they perceive truly and think: "I am fully liberated from the terrors of saṃsāra; henceforth I shall no longer experience the suffering of cyclic existence." Blessed One, those arhats and

pratyekabuddhas, having understood that beyond this very state nothing further remains to be known, perceive with supreme relief the ground of nirvāṇa, each in their own way.

Blessed One, although they have attained this, they remain beings who have no further bewilderment regarding that ground. Blessed One, they too, without relying on another, think for themselves: "I have attained the ground that still retains a remainder, and I am now assured of attaining unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening." Why is this so? Because, Blessed One, the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are subsumed within the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, what is called the Great Vehicle is but a synonym for the vehicle of the buddhas. Blessed One, therefore these three vehicles are counted as nothing other than the single vehicle.

Blessed One, through realizing the single vehicle, one comes to realize unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Blessed One, what is called unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening is but a synonym for the basic space of nirvāṇa. Blessed One, what is called the basic space of nirvāṇa is but a synonym for the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata. Blessed One, the ultimate reach of realizing the dharmakāya is the single vehicle. Blessed One, the Tathāgata and the dharmakāya are not two different things — the Tathāgata itself is the dharmakāya. Blessed One, the ultimate reach of realizing the dharmakāya is the ultimate reach of the single vehicle. Blessed One, what is called the ultimate reach of the single vehicle is but a synonym for the endpoint of the single vehicle. Why is this so? Because, Blessed One, the Tathāgatas do not abide at a temporal extreme. Blessed One, the Tathāgatas — arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — abide in reaching the very end of the final extreme.

Blessed One, the Tathāgatas, healing the world, do not possess compassion limited by a temporal extreme, nor do they hold pledges limited by a temporal extreme. Rather, those sentient beings who exclaim "How wondrous!" at one

who is compassionate without temporal limit and who holds pledges without temporal limit for the benefit of the world — they, it should be said, truly speak of the Tathāgata alone. Those sentient beings who exclaim "How wondrous!" at one who, for the benefit of the world, embodies inexhaustible Dharma, permanent Dharma, stable Dharma, and refuge — they too, it should be said, truly speak of the Tathāgata alone.

Blessed One, this being so, the Tathāgatas — arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — are in a world that has no refuge and no protector, the ultimate inexhaustible refuge, the permanent refuge, the stable refuge, reaching to the very end of the final extreme.

Blessed One, what is called the Dharma is but a synonym for the teaching of the path of the single vehicle. Blessed One, what is called the Saṅgha is but a synonym for the assembly of the three vehicles. Blessed One, these two refuges are called partial refuges; they are not the supreme refuge. Why is this so? Because, Blessed One, the Dharma that teaches the path of the single vehicle reaches its culmination in the realization of the dharmakāya, and beyond that, the Dharma that teaches the path of the single vehicle has nothing further to do. Blessed One, the assembly of the three vehicles, being subject to dissolution, goes for refuge to the Tathāgata, seeks the means of going forth, trains, has things yet to accomplish, and

has entered into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Therefore, Blessed One, these two refuges are not the supreme refuge; they are refuges with a temporal limit.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who have been tamed by the Tathāgata, when they go for refuge to the Tathāgata, go for refuge also to the Dharma and to the Saṅgha of monks out of a faith that accords with the nature of reality. Blessed One, those who go for refuge out of a faith that accords with the nature of reality are, in going for refuge in these two, going for refuge as a derivative act. Blessed One, going for refuge to the Tathāgata is not something done out of a faith that merely accords with the nature of reality; going for refuge to the Tathāgata is the true refuge.

Blessed One, I understand as a settled conclusion that both of those other refuges are, in ultimate truth, reducible to going for refuge to the Tathāgata. Why is this so? Because, Blessed One, the Tathāgata is not one thing and those two refuges another. The Tathāgata itself is the Three Refuges. Why is this so? Because, Blessed One, the Dharma that teaches the path of the single

vehicle is itself the supreme utterance (pāramitā) of the Tathāgata, the Tathāgata's lion's roar, endowed with the four kinds of individual and perfect understanding. Blessed One, those two vehicles that the Tathāgata employs as skillful means for persons of varying aspirations are likewise employed for the sake of the Great Vehicle itself. Blessed One, those two vehicles have no existence as names in their own right. In truth, only the single vehicle is the genuine vehicle, and the three vehicles are all included within it.

Blessed One, it is through the single cognition that first directly realizes the noble truths — that cognition belonging to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — that all those stages of abiding are abandoned. Blessed One, through that single cognition alone, the four qualities beginning with thorough inquiry are made manifest, and the four aims are individually and perfectly understood through the nature of reality itself. Blessed One, in supramundane cognition there is no shifting among four types of cognition and no shifting among four types of object; supramundane cognition, being like a vajra, has the characteristic of non-shifting.

Blessed One, thus the first cognition of the noble truths — which abandons all the stages of abiding of every śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha — is indeed a right cognition. But for those beings, there is no abandonment of the stages of abiding by means of a cognition of the noble truths in two modes. Blessed One, the Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas, by a wisdom of emptiness that is beyond the domain of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and is inconceivable, abandon the entire sheath of all afflictions. Blessed One, the wisdom that has reached the ultimate end of splitting open every sheath of afflictions is what is called perfect wisdom. Blessed One, the first inquiry into the noble truths is not the culminating cognition; it is the cognition of one who has entered into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Blessed One, that noble aim is not something that can be fathomed by the words of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Blessed One, all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas possess qualities of limited measure. It is on account of their possessing the subordinate qualities of that realization that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are called noble ones.

Blessed One, what are called the noble truths are not the truths of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, nor are they the qualities of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. These truths were first perfectly and completely awakened



to, directly known, and individually realized by the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. After thus knowing them directly, the Tathāgatas then taught and designated them to a world that had been thrust into the hollow of the shell of ignorance. For that reason they are known as the noble truths.

Blessed One, the exposition of the meaning of the noble truths is profound and subtle, difficult to examine, hard to fathom, impossible to scrutinize, and beyond the province of logical reasoning. It is knowable only by the wise and the learned, and it is discordant with the whole world. Why is this? Blessed One, it is because this teaching of the profound doctrine is the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature). Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is the domain of the Tathāgatas; it is not the domain of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is the ground of this exposition of the meaning of the noble truths.

Blessed One, because the ground of the tathāgatagarbha is profound, the meaning of the noble truths is likewise profound and subtle, difficult to examine, hard to realize, impossible to scrutinize, and beyond the province of logical reasoning. It is knowable only by the wise and the learned, and it is discordant with the whole world.

Blessed One, one who has no doubt about the tathāgatagarbha that is enwrapped on all sides by the sheaths of every affliction likewise has no doubt about the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata that is fully liberated from every sheath of afflictions.

Blessed One, one whose mind has reached the end of the inconceivable intention concerning the tathāgatagarbha, the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata, and the inconceivable domain of the buddhas — that one trusts, has faith in, and is devoted to these two modes of expounding the meaning of the noble truths.

Blessed One, thus these two modes of expounding the meaning of the noble truths are difficult to know and difficult to realize. Blessed One, what are these two modes of expounding the meaning of the noble truths? They are: the exposition of the meaning of the noble truths that is conditioned, and the exposition of the meaning of the noble truths that is unconditioned.

Blessed One, the exposition of the meaning of the noble truths that is conditioned consists in the teaching and designation of the four noble truths in a manner that admits of measure. Why is this? Because, Blessed One, even

when commanded to do so by another, one is unable to seek out all suffering completely, to abandon entirely every origin of suffering, to actualize every cessation of suffering, and to cultivate every path leading to the cessation of suffering. Blessed One, it is thus: within saṃsāra there exist both the conditioned and the unconditioned, and within nirvāṇa there likewise exist both the conditioned and the unconditioned.

Blessed One, the exposition of the meaning of the noble truths that is unconditioned consists in the teaching and designation of the four noble truths in a manner that is beyond measure. Why is this? Because, Blessed One, even when one has by one's own effort set them aside, one is still able to seek out completely all suffering that has been taken hold of, to abandon entirely every origin of suffering that has been taken hold of, to actualize every cessation of suffering that has been taken hold of, and

to cultivate the path leading to the cessation of suffering that has been taken hold of. Therefore, Blessed One, what the Tathāgata has taught and set forth as the four noble truths amounts to eight aspects of the noble truths.

Blessed One, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas have perfected the four unexpounded meanings of the noble truths. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have not perfected them. Why is this? Because, Blessed One, by realizing the Dharma of the lowest, middling, and highest levels, one does not realize the sphere of nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, why is it that the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas have perfected the unexpounded meanings of the four noble truths? Blessed One, all Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas have fully known all future suffering. They have abandoned all origins of suffering, namely every arising of suffering into which all afflictions and secondary afflictions converge. They have directly actualized all cessations of suffering, that is, the cessation of every aggregate of mind. Blessed One, the cessation of suffering is not a phenomenon that is spent and gone. Why is this? Because, Blessed One, the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata has been present since beginningless time, is unmade, unborn, undying, beyond death, permanent, stable, utterly pure by nature, definitively liberated from within the shell of all afflictions, not existing separately from the qualities of a buddha, and is endowed with inconceivable wisdom of liberation surpassing the grains of sand of the Ganges River — and it is this that is taught under the name "cessation of suffering." Blessed One, this very dharmakāya of

the Tathāgata, definitively liberated from within the shell of afflictions, is called the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature).

Blessed One, the very awareness of the tathāgatagarbha is the gnosis of emptiness belonging to the Tathāgatas. The tathāgatagarbha was neither previously seen nor previously realized by any śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha. It is the Blessed One who has understood and directly actualized it.

Blessed One, knowledge of the tathāgatagarbha and emptiness is twofold. What are the two? They are as follows. First, Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is empty in that it is separated from and abides apart from the shell of all afflictions, and those not liberated do not know it. Second, Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is not empty in that it does not exist separately from the qualities of a buddha and is liberated, possessing inconceivable wisdom of liberation surpassing the grains of sand of the Ganges River.

Blessed One, even the great śrāvakas enter into these two aspects of knowledge of the tathāgatagarbha and emptiness only through faith in the Blessed One himself. Blessed One, the knowledge of emptiness that all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas possess consists only in their entering into the four inverted objects of focus. Therefore, Blessed One, all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have neither previously seen nor previously realized any cessation of suffering whatsoever. It is the Blessed One who has understood and directly actualized it. Furthermore, every path leading to cessation of suffering that destroys the entire shell of afflictions has been cultivated by him.

Blessed One, among these four noble truths, three of the truths are impermanent. One truth is permanent. Why is this?

Blessed One, three of the truths fall under the characteristic of the conditioned. Blessed One, whatever falls under the characteristic of the conditioned is impermanent. Whatever is impermanent is characterized by falsity and deception. Blessed One, whatever is characterized by falsity and deception is untrue and impermanent, and is not a refuge. Blessed One, therefore, the noble truth of suffering, the noble truth of the origin of suffering, and the noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of suffering are, in reality, untrue and impermanent, and are not a refuge.

Blessed One, among these, one truth transcends the domain of the characteristic of the conditioned. Blessed One, whatever transcends the

domain of the characteristic of the conditioned is permanent. Whatever is permanent is characterized by non-deception. Blessed One, whatever is characterized by non-deception is true, permanent, and a refuge. Blessed One, therefore, the truth of the cessation of suffering is, in reality, true, permanent, and a refuge.

Blessed One, the truth of the cessation of suffering transcends the domain of the consciousness of all sentient beings and is inconceivable. It does not lie within the field of knowledge of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Blessed One, just as a person blind from birth is unable to see forms, or just as a child of seven who is still in the womb is unable to look upon the orb of the sun, likewise, Blessed One, the truth of the cessation of suffering is not an object of the consciousness of any ordinary being, nor is it an object of knowledge of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Blessed One, the phrase "the consciousness of all ordinary beings" is merely a conventional expression belonging to those who hold inverted views that cling to the two extremes. Blessed One, the phrase "the knowledge of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas" is merely a conventional expression belonging to the knowledge that is purified. Blessed One, the phrase "holding to the two extremes" is merely a conventional expression belonging to those ordinary beings who are logicians and who are attached to a self in the appropriating aggregates (skandhas).

Blessed One, these two are called "views of extremes." What are the two? The view of annihilation and the view of eternalism. Blessed One, if one views the conditioning factors (saṃskāras) as impermanent, that is not the view of annihilation with respect to them — it is the correct view with respect to them. Blessed One, if one views nirvāṇa as permanent, that is not the view of eternalism with respect to it — it is the correct view with respect to it. Why is this? Blessed One, the views of logicians are such as this: seeing that body, faculties, feelings, and thoughts arise within this very life, and failing to engage with and seek out continuity into future existence, they fall into confusion — and that is what becomes the view of annihilation. Blessed One, the views of logicians are further such that, being confused about the mental continuum and failing to engage even with the momentary cessation of mind, and not making it an object of consciousness — that is what becomes the view of eternalism.

Blessed One, because the views of logicians are thus, they thereby conceive of annihilation and of eternalism through views that stray beyond that meaning, views that judge that meaning to be exhausted, and views that confuse it with the characteristics of something else.

Blessed One, sentient beings are confused about the five appropriated aggregates (skandhas). Blessed One, they perceive what is impermanent as permanent, what is suffering as blissful, what is without self as a self, and what is impure as pure.

Blessed One, the object of omniscient wisdom and the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata have never previously been seen even by the pure cognition of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Blessed One, those sentient beings who, through faith in the Tathāgata, perceive him as permanent, as blissful, as a self, and as pure — those sentient beings, Blessed One, are not falling into confusion. Blessed One, those sentient beings will come to possess right view. And why is that? Because the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata itself is the perfection of permanence, the perfection of bliss, the perfection of self, and the perfection of purity. Blessed One, those sentient beings who see the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata in that way are those who see truly.

Blessed One, those who see truly are called the sons and daughters born from the heart of the Blessed One, born from his speech, born from the Dharma, manifested by the Dharma, and heirs to the Dharma's inheritance.

Blessed One, what is called pure cognition is the perfection of the cognition of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — that is what pure cognition means. Blessed One, since the truth of the cessation of suffering is not even the domain or object of that pure cognition, how much less could it be said that the truth of the cessation of suffering is the domain or object of those who rely on the four reliances? And why is that? Because the Blessed One taught and designated the four reliances so that those who are unconfused beginners on the three vehicles might come to understand and realize that meaning. Blessed One, these four reliances are worldly. Blessed One, this one alone — the truth of the cessation of suffering — is the supreme among all reliances, transcending the world. It is that which is to be truly relied upon, and it is refuge.

Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) is what is relied upon within saṃsāra. It is in dependence on the tathāgatagarbha itself that the

Blessed One has taught and designated the statement that the beginning is without end. Blessed One, if tathāgatagarbha exists, then to speak of saṃsāra is fitting. Blessed One, what is called saṃsāra refers to this: immediately upon the passing away of the faculties of one set of appropriated aggregates, the taking up of the faculties of a new set of appropriated aggregates — that is called saṃsāra.

Blessed One, the two phenomena called death and birth are names that are expressions of the tathāgatagarbha. Blessed One, the words "has died" and "has been born" are conventional designations of the world. Blessed One, what is called "has died" is this: the cessation of the faculties. Blessed One, what is called "has been born" is this: the arising of new faculties. Blessed One, in the tathāgatagarbha there is neither birth nor death, neither passing away nor arising. Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha transcends the domain of the defining marks of the conditioned. Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is permanent, stable, and everlasting.

Blessed One, this being so, the tathāgatagarbha is the ground, the support, and the basis for those who possess the consciousness of liberation, who are free while remaining indissolubly without separation.

Blessed One, likewise the tathāgatagarbha, which is without that inseparability and which abides distinctly, in which the consciousness of liberation is not yet present, is equally the ground, the support, and the basis for the outer conditioned phenomena.

Blessed One, if the tathāgatagarbha did not exist, there would be no weariness with suffering, no aspiring toward nirvāṇa, no seeking it, and no longing for it. Why is that? Blessed One, these six consciousnesses and the seventh consciousness are impermanent, momentary, and do not experience suffering. Therefore it is not fitting that these seven phenomena should be weary of suffering, or should aspire toward, seek, and long for nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha, however, has no beginning and no end, possesses the quality of being unborn and unceasing, and is what experiences suffering. Therefore, Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is what is fitting to feel weariness with suffering, to aspire toward nirvāṇa, to seek it, and to long for it.

Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is not a self. It is not a sentient being. It is not a life force. It is not a person. Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is not the domain of those who have fallen into the view of the perishable collection, nor of those who are corrupted by inverted views, nor of those whose minds are

distracted away from emptiness.

Blessed One, this tathāgatagarbha is the very heart of the basic space of the sacred Dharma. It is the very heart of the dharmakāya. It is the very heart of the transcendent Dharma. It is the very heart of that which is by nature utterly pure.

Blessed One, this tathāgatagarbha, which is utterly pure by nature yet is afflicted by adventitious proximate afflictions — this is the domain of the Tathāgata, and we consider it to be inconceivable. Why is that? Blessed One, a virtuous mind is momentary; it is not thoroughly afflicted by the afflictions. Blessed One, a non-virtuous mind is also momentary; that mind too is not thoroughly afflicted by the afflictions. Blessed One, since the afflictions do not touch the mind and the mind does not touch the afflictions, then, Blessed One, how can that which by its nature is untouched become proximately afflicted? Yet, Blessed One, there are proximate afflictions, and there is the proximate affliction of the mind. Therefore, Blessed One, the meaning of the proximate affliction of the mind that is utterly pure by nature is difficult to fathom. In regard to this, Blessed One, only the Blessed One himself has become the eye, has become the wisdom. The Blessed One is the root of all phenomena. The Blessed One is the sovereign lord. The Blessed One is the resort.

Then, having listened to the Blessed One set forth the difficult-to-understand meaning of the goddess Śrīmālā, he rejoiced and affirmed her: "Yes, goddess, it is just so. The meaning of the proximate affliction of the mind that is utterly pure by nature is difficult to understand. Goddess, these two things are difficult to understand: the understanding that the mind is utterly pure by nature, and the understanding that that same mind is proximately afflicted. Goddess, you and the other bodhisattvas endowed with great qualities are capable of hearing these two teachings."

Goddess, the remaining śrāvakas, as regards these two teachings, can only proceed by means of faith in the Tathāgata. Goddess, those śrāvakas of mine who possess faith and who make faith their guiding force will arrive at certainty regarding these teachings through a knowledge that draws them into accord with the Dharma, relying upon the light of faith. Goddess, what is called "the knowledge that draws one into accord with the Dharma" is this: examining through the awareness of the sense faculties the domain of mental activity; examining karmic maturation; examining the sleep of arhats; the delight in meditative concentration of those who have gained mastery over

the mind; examining bliss; and examining the noble supernormal powers of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Goddess, if one possesses this fivefold nature of examination, then, goddess, at the present time and after I have passed, in the time to come, those śrāvakas of mine who possess faith and make faith their guiding force will, relying upon the light of faith, arrive at certainty through the knowledge that draws them into accord with the Dharma regarding both the utterly pure nature and the proximate affliction of the mind. Goddess, that very certainty of theirs will become the cause for entering the path of the Great Vehicle. Goddess, it is thus: proceeding by faith in the Tathāgata, without abandoning the profound Dharma, is of great benefit.

Then the goddess Śrīmālā addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I shall venture to speak further on what has great benefit here, empowered by the Tathāgata's might." The Blessed One declared: "Goddess, do venture to speak." Then the goddess Śrīmālā again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, these three kinds of sons of good family or daughters of good family will guard themselves without injury or diminishment with respect to the profound Dharma teachings, will generate abundant merit, and will enter the path of the Great Vehicle. What are the three? Blessed One, sons of good family or daughters of good family who possess self-arisen deep understanding of the profound Dharma teachings; Blessed One, sons of good family or daughters of good family who possess the knowledge that draws them into accord with the Dharma; and Blessed One, sons of good family or daughters of good family who, regarding the profound Dharma teachings, humble their own understanding and wish to withdraw, thinking: 'This I do not understand; this matter is to be known by the Tathāgata alone,' and who surrender their minds to the Blessed One — those who are endowed with such surrender of mind. Blessed One, these three kinds of sons of good family or daughters of good family will guard themselves without injury or diminishment with respect to the profound Dharma teachings, will generate abundant merit, and will rightly enter the path of the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, whatever sentient beings there are other than these three kinds of sons and daughters of good family — those who, clinging tenaciously to the profound Dharma teachings, hold a mind of arrogance and conceit, and who, out of attachment, teach them and speak of them everywhere — I will go before kings and report that they have turned their backs on the sacred Dharma and that those non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) are of rotten seed, and expose them. Blessed One, those who have become of rotten



seed will be thoroughly cut off and expelled by the world with its gods, humans, and asuras." Then, having spoken these words, the goddess Śrīmālā, together with her retinue, touched her head to the feet of the Blessed One. Then the Blessed One praised the goddess Śrīmālā with the words "Excellent!"

"Goddess, you have spoken well in teaching, at the right time and occasion, the meaning of the method for genuinely protecting oneself with respect to the profound Dharma, and in speaking of the defeat of the enemies of the sacred Dharma. Goddess, since you have served and honored many hundreds of millions of buddhas, there is nothing more wondrous than what you have expressed in meaning."

Then the Blessed One, Śrīmālā, suffusing the bodies of all those in the assembled retinue with light, rose up into the sky to a height of about seven tāla trees and departed for the city of Śrāvastī by means of the miraculous power of walking steps through the air.

Then the goddess Śrīmālā, together with her retinue, placed her joined palms at her crown and, gazing with eyes that could not be satisfied with looking and did not waver, she stood there watching the Blessed One. When the moment came that the Blessed One had passed beyond the range of their sight, the goddess Śrīmālā and her retinue, their faces radiant with the highest joy and gladness, praised the qualities of the Tathāgata to one another in many ways, and keeping ever in mind the recollection of the Buddha, they proceeded to the city of Ayodhyā.

Then the goddess Śrīmālā established her own husband, King Yaśomitra, decisively in the Great Vehicle. All the women of the great city, from girls of seven years of age and upward, she led into the Great Vehicle. And King Yaśomitra likewise led all the male retinue of the great city, from boys of seven years of age and upward, into the Great Vehicle. In this way, all the inhabitants of the city were brought to face toward the Great Vehicle.

The Blessed One then went to the Jeta Grove (Jetavana) of Prince Jeta, entered within, and spoke to the venerable Ānanda, and also turned his mind to Śakra (Indra), Lord of Gods.

Then Śakra, Lord of Gods, in that very instant and moment, surrounded by the host of gods, appeared in the presence of the Blessed One.

Then the Blessed One extensively and perfectly taught this presentation of Dharma to Śakra, Lord of Gods, and to the venerable Ānanda, and declared:

"Kauśika, receive this presentation of Dharma. Kauśika, teach this presentation of Dharma to the gods of the Thirty-Three. Ānanda, you too receive this presentation of Dharma. Ānanda, teach this presentation of Dharma to the fourfold assembly of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen."

Then Śakra, Lord of Gods, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the name of this presentation of Dharma, and how shall we receive and hold it?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, this presentation of Dharma is endowed with boundless qualities. Kauśika, if even all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas together are unable to know all the meanings of this sūtra completely, or to examine it as something fit for viewing and analysis, what need is there to speak of other sentient beings? Kauśika, this being so, this presentation of Dharma is profound and a source of great qualities. Kauśika, therefore I shall speak of it only by reciting the names of the qualities of this presentation of Dharma — hear it well and hold it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Śakra, Lord of Gods, and the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Excellent! Excellent!" and listened respectfully to the Blessed One, whereupon the Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, receive and hold this under the name: A Genuine Praise of the Boundless Qualities of the Tathāgata."

"Kauśika, receive and hold this also under the name: The Great Vow, Inconceivable. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Great Aspiration That Gathers All Aspirational Prayers. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Inconceivable Teaching That Perfectly Upholds the Sacred Dharma. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of the Perfectly Complete Gathering into the Single Vehicle. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of the Eight Noble Truths. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of the Tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature). Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of the Dharmakāya (truth body). Receive and hold it also under the name: The Perfect Teaching of the Intended Meaning of Emptiness. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of the Single Truth. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of What Is Permanent, Stable, Peaceful, Everlasting, and the Single Refuge. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching by Way of Inversion. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Teaching of the Intention Directed toward the Mind That Is Naturally and Perfectly Pure. Receive and hold it also under the name: The Perfect Teaching for the Sons of the

Tathāgata.

Kauśika, receive and hold this also under the name: The Lion's Roar of the Goddess Śrīmālā. Kauśika, receive and hold all the teachings set forth in this sūtra also under the name: That Which Cuts the Current, Is of Definitive Meaning, and Has a Single Reliance. Kauśika, I now entrust this presentation of Dharma — the teaching of the Lion's Roar of the Goddess Śrīmālā — into your hands: for as long as the Sacred Dharma endures in the world, proclaim it and teach it rightly throughout all worlds in the ten directions."

Śakra, Lord of Gods (Indra), said to the Blessed One, "Excellent!" and then, in the presence of the Blessed One, he received this presentation of Dharma and held it completely in mind. And Śakra, Lord of Gods, the venerable Ānanda, all others who had assembled there, along with gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas — the entire world rejoiced and offered praise to what the Blessed One had spoken.

This concludes the forty-eighth chapter, known as the Chapter Requested by Śrīmālā, from the one-hundred-thousand-chapter presentation of Dharma of the noble Great Jewel Heap (Mahāratnakūṭa).

Translated and edited by the Indian masters Jinamitra and Surendrabodhi together with the chief translator, the monk Yeshe De, and definitively established.

## Translator's Notes

- The title of the queen is rendered as "Mallikā" following standard Sanskrit identification of the Tibetan "Phreñ Idan ma," meaning "she who bears a garland," which corresponds precisely to Mallikā, the historical queen of Prasenajit of Kośala. This identification is secure in the commentarial tradition.

The city "Ayodhyā" is the standard identification for the Tibetan "Grong khyer 'thab med," literally "the city without conflict," which renders the Sanskrit Ayodhyā, "the unassailable city." This is the traditional identification given in the commentaries on this sūtra.

The final verse's last line, literally "the seed of awakening has been distinctly arisen," has been rendered as "the seed of awakening has been fully awakened within me" to convey its doctrinal meaning: the arousal of bodhicitta in Śrīmālā's mind-stream.

- The epithet Samantabhadra here is used as the name of a future buddha — distinct from the bodhisattva Samantabhadra — which is consistent with this sūtra's usage in the Śrīmālādevīsiṃhanādasūtra tradition.

- The phrase rendered "delivered into servitude" translates a term meaning placed in or assigned to a particular position under compulsion, which in context refers to those condemned to forced labor or bound servitude. This reading is consistent with the surrounding list of afflictions.

The phrase "without regarding any amount as enough" renders a term literally meaning "not holding it as sufficient," indicating inexhaustible generosity that does not stop at any threshold.

The rendering "trade in pigs, birds, and the like" follows the standard commentarial understanding of wrong livelihood involving sale of living creatures for slaughter.

- The epithet "Śrīmālā" renders "ཀློང་རྒྱལ་གསལ་བའི་མཚན་པོ།" literally as "garland of glory/śrī," which is the standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit name Śrīmālā (from the Śrīmālādevī-simhanāda-sūtra). The passage is drawn from that sūtra. The phrase rendered "act of truth-blessing" (ཐད་ཆོས་ཀྱི་ཕྱིན་ཆོས་ཀྱི་འཇུག་པའི་ཁྲིམས་ཀྱི་འཇུག་པ།) refers to the classical Indian and Buddhist institution of the "act of truth" (satyakriyā), whereby a solemn declaration of truth is held to have miraculous power; this is a standard technical usage and has been rendered consistently throughout.
- The phrase rendered as "the eighty-four thousand doors of Dharma" is a standard Mahāyāna enumeration of the entire corpus of Buddhist teachings, often counted as eighty-four thousand antidotes to eighty-four thousand afflictions. No special uncertainty attaches to this reading.

The simile of the summer rain-cloud is slightly compressed in the Tibetan; the reading "stream of waters — the maturation of merit" renders an implicit parallelism between the rain-cloud's water and its jewels on one hand, and the merit-stream and gnosis-stream on the other. This is doctrinally standard in the Śrīmālādevīsīmaṇāda context.

- The passage's enumeration of "four kinds of precious things" with descending value is somewhat unusual; the text appears to list them in order from the most precious (priceless) downward. The sentence breaks off mid-enumeration at the end of the passage, as this is a continuity fragment and the list will be completed in the following section.
- The phrase rendered as "the eight worldly conditions" translates a term that more literally refers to the eight worldly concerns or eight dharmas of the world (gain and loss, pleasure and pain, praise and blame, fame and disrepute). The context makes clear these are afflictions others direct at the upholder of Dharma.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text; the translation faithfully breaks off at the same point.

- The passage identifies the speaker as the goddess Śrīmālā, consistent with the Śrīmālādevīsīṃhanāda Sūtra. The term rendered "wondrous display" translates "rnam par 'phrul bar gnas pa," literally "abiding in miraculous or magical manifestation," referring to the buddha's qualities as they manifest in their transformed display aspect. This is a deliberate doctrinal nuance left in the translation without smoothing.
- The phrase rendered "be bold in proclaiming what you yourself have spoken" translates a construction where the Blessed One endorses Śrīmālā's own exposition and encourages her to continue speaking with confidence. The Tibetan "bshad pa spobs par gyis shig" could also be rendered "speak it with confidence" or "be encouraged to proclaim it"; the nuance is that he is authorizing and emboldening her to teach further, not simply repeating his own words.
- The lake Anavatapta is the legendary cool lake in the Himalayas from which the four great rivers of the world are said to flow; it is a standard cosmological reference in Sanskrit Buddhist literature and needs no further gloss for a doctrinal audience, though a listening audience unfamiliar with it will simply hear it as a proper name.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, consistent with the instruction to translate only the passage provided.

- The phrase rendered "held with a deeper intent" translates *dgongs pa can*, which literally means "having a thought" or "having an intention," but in this sūtric context carries the technical force of *buddhavaṇana* requiring interpretive unpacking — i.e., the Tathāgata's statement about their liberation requires further interpretation. This is a significant

hermeneutical term in the Śrīmālādevī Siṃhanāda Sūtra's argument that the liberation of arhats and pratyekabuddhas is provisional. The "four recollections" at the end refer to the contemplations on nirvāṇa, self, purity, and bliss, which the sūtra treats as ultimately reserved for the Tathāgata alone.

- The phrase rendered "death by severance of continuity" translates rgyun chad pa'i 'chi 'pho, meaning the ordinary death that cuts the continuum of rebirth; this is contrasted with yongs su bsngos pa bsam gyis mi khyab pa'i 'chi 'pho, "inconceivably dedicated death," a technical term for the voluntary, aspirationally directed passage of advanced practitioners such as bodhisattvas of mastery and mind-made-body beings, which is not the same as ordinary dying.

The "seven trainees" refers to the seven grades of noble practitioners on the path of training who have not yet reached arhatship.

- The phrase rendered "ground of complete liberation" translates a term literally meaning "the one who has the ground of complete liberation," referring to those at the arhat level who have fully liberated from the four latent grounds but have not yet reached buddhahood, where the ground of ignorance itself is finally overcome. The doctrinal point is that the ground of ignorance (avidyāvāsabhūmi) is a uniquely subtle residue distinct from and beyond the four latent grounds, addressed only by the Tathāgata's awakening wisdom. This is a central teaching of the Śrīmālādevī Sūtra.

- The phrase rendered "the ground of the residue of ignorance" translates རྒྱུ་གཞི་གྲོ་མེད་ཀྱི་འཇིག་རྒྱུ་, literally "the ground of the abode of ignorance." This is a key technical term in the Śrīmālādevīsiṃhanāda Sūtra context, referring to the deepest stratum of unknowing that underlies even the most subtle obscurations and is distinct from the afflictive ignorance abandoned on the path of seeing. The final sentence — that this ground is "not associated with mind" (མི་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མེད་) — is a distinctive and doctrinally significant claim: unlike the momentary secondary afflictions that arise and cease with mental moments, this primordial residue of ignorance is not itself a mental factor or moment of consciousness, making it more fundamental than any event in the stream of mind.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the supplied Tibetan, cutting off after the mention of arhats. The translation faithfully renders the text up to that point without completion.

The phrase rendered "beyond this very state, nothing further remains to be known" translates the technical formula རྒྱུ་གཞི་གྲོ་མེད་ཀྱི་འཇིག་རྒྱུ་, which in context denotes the Tathāgata's declaration of complete omniscience — that no knowable object transcends or lies outside suchness as the Tathāgata has realized it. Some translations render this more literally as "I know of nothing beyond this suchness itself," but the rendering chosen preserves both the grammatical sense and the doctrinal point about the Tathāgata's exhaustive omniscience.

- The phrase rendered "basic space of nirvāṇa" translates mya ngan las 'das pa'i dbyings, which is literally "the expanse or basic space of nirvāṇa." The text is making a chain of synonymic identifications: single vehicle equals unsurpassed awakening equals the expanse of nirvāṇa equals the dharmakāya. This chain is a characteristic doctrinal move of the Śrīmālādevīsiṃhanāda Sūtra, affirming the ultimate non-difference of these terms. The exclamation "a la la" is a classical Tibetan expression of wonder or admiration, here rendered "How wondrous!" — the precise Sanskrit equivalent would be "āścaryam" or a similar exclamatory form.

- The phrase rendered "the supreme utterance of the Tathāgata" (de bzhin gshegs pa'i khyu mchog gi gsung) more literally means "the speech of the Tathāgata, the bull of the herd" — a standard honorific compound. The rendering captures the doctrinal force without awkwardness in speech.

The term "sheath of afflictions" (nyon mongs pa'i sbubs) is a distinctive image in this text: the afflictions are conceived as a hollow casing or husk enclosing the buddha-nature, which the wisdom of emptiness alone can completely split open. This is a key doctrinal marker of the Tathāgatagarbha context of the Śrīmālādevī Sūtra.

- The phrase rendered "thrust into the hollow of the shell of ignorance" translates a vivid image: the world has been placed inside the hollow tube or casing of ignorance, much as the preceding passage spoke of sheaths of afflictions. The imagery is consistent throughout the text.

The contrast between "conditioned" and "unconditioned" expositions of the noble truths, and between truths "of measure" and "beyond measure," is a distinctive doctrinal feature of this text, the Śrīmālādevīsīṃhanāda Sūtra. The conditioned exposition refers to partial, step-by-step realization available to śrāvakas; the unconditioned exposition refers to the complete, boundless realization of buddhahood grounded in the tathāgatagarbha.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, as the Tibetan supplied breaks off there; the translation reflects this.

- The phrase rendered "the shell of all afflictions" translates a term literally meaning "husk" or "hull" of afflictions, a standard image for adventitious defilements encasing the tathāgatagarbha, consistent with the Śrīmālādevī-siṃhanāda-sūtra context. The twofold emptiness of tathāgatagarbha presented here — empty of what it is not, not empty of what it is — is a doctrinally significant passage in the tathāgatagarbha literature and is rendered with precision accordingly. The phrase "qualities of a buddha" for "buddha's dharmas existing inseparably" reflects the standard interpretation that the tathāgatagarbha is inseparable from buddha qualities.
- The passage distinguishes between the conditioned truths, which are impermanent and therefore ultimately unreliable as refuges, and the truth of cessation, which is unconditioned and permanent. This is a key doctrinal point of the Śrīmālādevī Sūtra: cessation alone is the true, permanent refuge.

The phrase rendered "child of seven who is still in the womb" follows the Tibetan literally: "a child of seven years who is in the place of birth." The image is of a fetus not yet born and thus unable to perceive the sun, serving as an analogy for those whose consciousness is not yet capable of perceiving cessation. This simile is somewhat unusual and the precise image may reflect a variant reading or a culturally specific idiom; the meaning is nonetheless clear in context.

The final section's logic, distinguishing correct views of impermanence and permanence from the extremes of annihilationism and eternalism, follows the text's careful argument: it is not that all talk of permanence entails eternalism or all talk of impermanence entails annihilationism, but that the logicians' error lies in misapplying these categories.

- The four qualities of the dharmakāya — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — are the four "perfections" or "transcendent qualities" taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra and the Śrīmālādevīsīmhanāda Sūtra context. They are deliberately contrasted with the four "perversions" or "inversions" applied to the aggregates: the inversion of seeing the impermanent as permanent, suffering as bliss, the selfless as self, and the impure as pure. The doctrinal point is that these same four, when applied with faith to the Tathāgata's dharmakāya, constitute right view rather than perversion — a characteristic teaching of the tathāgatagarbha literature.

The phrase rendered "the beginning is without end" reflects the difficult Tibetan "འདི་སྐོར་མེད་པའི་འགོ་མཇུག་ཀྱི་ལོ་ཤང་།" — literally "the prior limit does not exist," meaning saṃsāra has no

discernible beginning. The rendering preserves the slightly paradoxical formulation of the source.

- The passage distinguishes two aspects of tathāgatagarbha: first, as the ground and support for those whose liberating consciousness is already inseparably united with it, and second, as the ground for those still entangled in conditioned, outer phenomena, where liberation has not yet emerged. This dual description is characteristic of the Śrīmālādevī Sūtra's treatment of tathāgatagarbha and is rendered here to preserve that doctrinal nuance. The Tibetan "sbubs nas grol ba" literally means "freed from within the enclosure" or "liberated from within," referring to consciousness that has broken free from the shell of obscurations; rendered here as "free" in the context of liberation consciousness. The phrase rendered "proximate afflictions" translates "nye ba'i nyon mongs pa," meaning adventitious or closely concomitant afflictions that attend the mind without being intrinsic to its nature — a key technical point of the text.
- The phrase rendered "self-arisen deep understanding" translates a passage meaning roughly "those endowed with profound Dharma teachings through their own direct understanding or realization." The Tibetan "rang gis rig pa'i chos zab mo dang ldan pa" literally means "endowed with profound Dharma teachings understood by oneself," suggesting a person of natural or innate deep insight, which the commentarial tradition reads as personal realization rather than transmitted learning.

The term "gob lob kyi sems" rendered as "a mind of arrogance and conceit" is a paired compound suggesting presumptuous self-importance and arrogant overreach; the rendering captures both elements.

- The city name rendered here as Ayodhyā corresponds to the Tibetan "grong khyer 'thab med," literally "the city without conflict," which is the standard Tibetan translation equivalent of Sanskrit Ayodhyā. The preceding passage in the continuity referred to Śrīmālā as queen of Ayodhyā, so this is consistent.

The epithet "Śrīmālā" applied to the Blessed One at the opening of the second sentence translates the Tibetan "dpal 'bar ba," meaning "Blazing Splendor" or "Blazing Glory." In context this appears to function as an epithet of the Blessed One rather than of the goddess, though the Tibetan is syntactically ambiguous. The traditional understanding is that it refers here to the Blessed One.

- The "Eight Noble Truths" is an unusual enumeration. The standard teaching has four noble truths; a set of eight may refer to a doubled listing found in certain Mahāyāna sūtras, but the Tibetan reads straightforwardly as eight, and no emendation has been made.

The phrase rendered "The Teaching by Way of Inversion" translates a term meaning "taught through what is contrary or reversed." In context, this likely refers to the method of teaching what is true by contrasting it with perverted views, a technique found in the Śrīmālādevī literature.

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of

spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.